Pohankar. Through his Hazrat Amir Khusrau Project, he will present some rare and ancient classical compositions and also some folk melodies. "My instrumental classical solo on the keyboard would also be one of the highlights," he adds.

Komkali, who is also performing at the festival for the first time, shares that it is a special feeling to perform a tribute to her father and guru. "Pandit Kumar Gandharva was a musician par excellence and along with several classical ragas and their compositions, he sang wonderful poetry of many saint poets, including a few of Nanak Sahib. I will try to perform some of them for this occasion," she says.

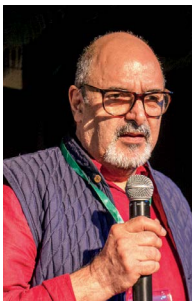
Participants will also have the opportunity to visit the Jallianwala Bagh, the Partition Museum and the Golden Temple to engage with history in a meaningful way. "These experiences connect past and present, making the festival not just a celebration but also a journey through history and cultural continuity," Roy signs off. ■

–Deepali Dhingra



RAHUL DEO







ONE OF A KIND Clockwise from left, Festival director Dadi D. Pudumjee, 'Pay Attention to Those Two' (Italy), 'The Rock' (Turkey)

ART

Puppet Play

The **Ishara International Puppet Theatre Festival 2025** features a rich variety of acts from around the world

The 21st edition of the Ishara International Puppet Theatre Festival will return to the capital's India Habitat Centre from February 21 to March 2. Audiences can experience everything from traditional hand puppets and intricate marionettes to cutting-edge digital and mesmerising shadow puppetry, all woven into compelling storytelling by puppeteers from across the globe.

"The only puppet festival in India of its kind, Ishara has brought unique modern and traditional puppet theatres from the Americas, the European continent, Africa, the Middle East, Russia, Southeast Asia and many more. The unique family festival brings together young and old, to laugh, cry and look at the world through the lens of the other," says Dadi D. Pudumjee, festival director and founder of the Ishara Puppet Theatre Trust.

This year's line-up promises to push artistic boundaries and offer something unique. 'Theatre in the Pocket' (Russia) is an interactive street theatre experience, featuring vibrant puppets, lively music and unforgettable vignettes. "It is a fun, kind and heartwarming show for all ages. Every puppet is made by our hands, and we put our souls and the idea of how street puppet theatre should be," says Dmitrii Orlov (Magic Hat), its performer. 'Life (Vida)' (Spain) is an intimate performance conveying that one should always move forward in life. "It is an essential vision of existence performed with two hands, humour and love," explains its director Javier Aranda.

The 21st edition of the puppet festival is being held at **INDIA HABITAT CENTRE** in New Delhi from Feb. 21 to Mar. 2

This year's edition features three shows from Italy: 'Pay Attention to Those Two' is a hilarious musical show featuring the mischievous duo, Giulio and Fabiola; 'Io, Pulcinella' is a celebration of four centuries of Neapolitan culture featuring Italy's beloved puppet, Pulcinella; and 'Jukebox' is a high-energy musical show, featuring surreal characters, puppetry and audience interaction.

From India, there is 'Monkey & the Crocodile', an adaptation of the timeless Indian folktale, brought to life by Puppet Studio India and directed by Manish Ram Sachdeva. Other highlights include 'Volar Volar (To Fly)' (Mexico), which follows the puppet Greta on a thought-provoking journey. 'The Rock' (Turkey) is a modern twist on an inspirational tale, showcasing how a simple solution can overcome a seemingly insurmountable problem. 'Sea of Possibilities' (Poland) is a mesmerising non-verbal musical performance inspired by Kobi Yamada's picture book *Maybe*. All in all, there's lots to look forward to. ■

– Neha Kirpal